Ganguly claims that the crises did not originate in the gradual acquisition of nuclear arsenals on the part of India and Pakistan. Instead their origins can be located in the exigencies of Indian and Pakistani domestic politics. Despite significant domestic political upheavals in both states, Pakistan's propensity to exploit Indian domestic political discontent, and a series of concomitant crises, war was avoided in South Asia because both sides were acutely cognizant of the dangers of escalation. The mutual possession of even incipient nuclear capabilities actually helped deter war and also contributed to the swift conclusion of multiple crises. In the prenuclear era, neither side had evinced a propensity for restraint during confrontations.

Kapur maintains that nuclear weapons facilitated the outbreak of Indo-Pakistani militarized disputes during the years in question. Specifically, by shielding Pakistan from all-out Indian conventional retaliation and promising to draw international attention to the Kashmir dispute, nuclear weapons encouraged provocative Pakistani behavior. This ranged from the provision of extensive material support for anti-Indian militancy in Kashmir to outright seizure of Indian territory by Pakistani forces. India responded forcefully to Pakistani provocations, and this triggered a cycle of regional violence. Kapur argues that although the resulting Indo-Pakistani crises ended without large-scale conventional war or nuclear escalation, such fortunate outcomes had little to do with nuclear deterrence. Rather, conflict resolution resulted from nonnuclear factors, including conventional military constraints and diplomatic calculations.

THE LATE 1980s

Although India and Pakistan tested nuclear weapons and became open nuclear powers in 1998, the nuclear era in South Asia began well before that. India first detonated a nuclear device in 1974. This peaceful nuclear explosion had few military implications.[2] Nonetheless, the PNE demonstrated India's potential to develop a nuclear weapons capability in the relatively near future. Together